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Banging Their HEADS

As diplomacy stalls, India plans a fresh offensive to regain momentum

It is a diplomatic sudoku that India is finding difficult to solve. In the aftermath of the Mumbai attacks, it seems India's efforts so far to use coercive diplomacy against Pakistan have yielded marginal returns, exposing just how limited its options are. With war hysteria mounting, international pressure built up on India and Pakistan to make reconciliatory gestures. The Directors-General of Military Operations of the two countries spoke over the weekend and the war rhetoric was toned down.

India is now initiating a fresh exercise to put the heat on Pakistan and isolate it internationally. India now plans to share evidence with almost a dozen countries whose nationals died in the Mumbai attacks. Ambassadors from these countries will be provided details from captured terrorist Ajmal Amir Kasab's confessions and the intercepts of the

telephone calls the terrorists made to their Pak-based L^{et} handlers during the attacks. Sources said the intercepts revealed the terrorists discussing the possibility of taking a 'minister' captive from among Indian and European lawmakers staying at the Taj Hotel. What India is aiming at is that Islamabad should not manage to rehyphenate the current stand-off to an Indo-Pak bilateral problem. "We are continuing to put international pressure, and our stand is that the issue is not of India and Pakistan, but that of terrorism, and the international community needs to pressure Pakistan," said External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee.

India is also heating up multi-lateral fora. Instructions have been issued to India's mission to the UN to persuade the spoiler nations for an early conclusion of the India-sponsored comprehensive convention on

international terrorism first put forward in 1996. The convention would allow international sanctions to be imposed against countries that harbour terrorists. Sources say that while Mukherjee has raised the issue with US Secretary of State Condoleezza Rice, efforts are also on to persuade Arab countries to bury their differences on the definition of terrorism which has held back the convention for the last 10 years. While this may be a long haul, it may force Pakistan to comply with its provisions. Delhi's biggest hope is that under sustained international pressure, Islamabad will hand over some prized fugitives, like L^{et} leaders besides Jaish-e-Mohammed leader Maulana Masood Azhar. This would also be a political bonanza for the UPA Government, ahead of the general elections and also because the NDA government had released him in December 1999 in exchange for hostages of IC-814. Since Pakistan has refused to hand over any Pakistani national to India, officials believe this may be difficult. Pakistan is also denying the presence of underworld don Dawood Ibrahim because of his drug-arms nexus with the ISI.

So while top government sources admit that its coercive diplomacy with Islamabad has not worked because of a multiplicity of power centres, it now wants the international community to deliver a strong message to the Pakistan Army and the ISI that they need to clean up their act. And in this, the successful conduct of elections in Kashmir may come as a force multiplier. This has provided impetus to India's diplomatic campaign that the central issue is that of terrorism, and its root cause does not lie in Kashmir where the voters have overwhelmingly rejected separatist calls for a boycott. Sources say the bigger problem is on the Pakistani side where Pakistan-controlled Kashmir has become a Wal-Mart of jihadi groups under active patronage of the ISI which needs an urgent cure. It is clear that the going will be tough for India in 2009.

INDIA WILL SHARE EVIDENCE AGAINST PAKISTAN WITH A DOZEN COUNTRIES.

by Saurabh Shukla